PRINT / OFFLINE

Music practice packet

Stories, seven activities, a flexible week plan and support prompts. Use your browser’s Print command or save the included PDF. Keep the extracted website folder together for offline reading. Your own notes stay with you.

DRAFTING · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2021

Black Thought

Keep a draft. See what changes.

In a 2021 interview, Black Thought described writing on a computer and in phone notes. He also found old notebooks containing drafts. In the same interview, he recalled leaving Millersville University and returning to Philadelphia.

The Paris Review · April 29, 2021 (https://www.theparisreview.org/blog/2021/04/29/everything-writes-itself-an-interview-with-black-thought/)

What to take from it

His account includes school and an interrupted college path. It does not show that leaving school caused success. Keeping a draft is one practice you can try without copying his life.

Try a small version

Keep four original lines. Change one detail in a second version. Which version gives a listener a clearer picture?

A route you can adapt

Ask a teacher, tutor or librarian to compare two versions of a paragraph or verse you choose to share.

FEEDBACK · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2014

Rapsody

Ask for something you can use.

Rapsody recalled that producer 9th Wonder heard her CD in late 2005. He told her it was a good start and that there were things to work on. She also described learning how much cadence and melody mattered.

Sonicbids · January 8, 2014 (https://blog.sonicbids.com/rapsody-interview)

What to take from it

This is her account of learning through feedback. It does not prove that every suggestion is useful. You can decide what fits your piece and keep your voice.

Try a small version

Ask a willing listener: “Which part stayed with you?” and “Where did you lose the idea?” Choose one change to try.

A route you can adapt

Use the same two questions with a teacher or tutor on a paragraph, presentation or piece of writing.

PLANNING · ORIGINAL INTERVIEW · 2020

Megan Thee Stallion

Make room for more than one goal.

In a 2020 PEOPLE interview, Megan was taking part-time online health-administration courses at Texas Southern University. She described fitting schoolwork around shows.

PEOPLE · June 28, 2020 (https://people.com/music/megan-thee-stallion-pursue-degree-make-late-mom-proud/)

What to take from it

Her story shows two goals happening together. It does not mean everyone needs college, or that school caused her music success. Your time and support may look different.

Try a small version

Choose one small music goal and one learning goal for this week. What help or time would each need?

A route you can adapt

Ask a counselor, teacher or trusted adult one specific question about a class, credits or another learning option.

CURIOSITY · FIRST-PERSON ARTICLE · 2015

GZA

Let a question become an idea.

In a 2015 article published under his name, GZA described science as a long-standing interest and a way to understand his surroundings. He connected that curiosity with subjects he wrote about.

Cuepoint / Medium · May 27, 2015 (https://medium.com/cuepoint/gza-speaks-the-lost-art-of-lyricism-ee84510e7268)

What to take from it

This is his account of an interest, not a science qualification or proof that one subject makes better music. You can choose a topic that matters to you; no artist gets to decide your taste.

Try a small version

Check one fact about a topic you like. Try two original lines using it. Keep a note of what the source actually supports.

A route you can adapt

Ask a librarian or subject teacher to help check a reference you want to use in a verse, paragraph or presentation.

PRODUCTION & COLLABORATION · FIRST-PERSON ACCOUNT · 2013

Erykah Badu / J Dilla

Choose a part. Explain a choice.

In her 2013 account, Erykah Badu recalled choosing a record and a passage from it. She said producer J Dilla taught her how to sample that passage.

Red Bull Music Academy Daily · February 21, 2013 (https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2013/02/when-erykah-met-dilla/)

What to take from it

This is Badu's recollection of a lesson, not a complete account of the recording process. Our activity uses material you create and needs no recording equipment.

Try a small version

Make four short phrases or patterns of your own. Choose one part to repeat. Compare two placements and explain what changes.

A route you can adapt

Ask a music or drama teacher, mentor or willing listener to compare your choices. You can work alone and keep the choice that fits your idea.

RETURNING TO A DRAFT · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2025

Little Simz

An earlier idea can have another use.

In a 2025 Song Exploder interview, Little Simz said she wrote a poem in spring 2022 and returned to it two years later while making “Free.”

Song Exploder · episode 294 · 2025; official transcript available (https://songexploder.net/little-simz)

What to take from it

This is her account of one song, not a schedule to follow or an explanation of fame. An earlier draft can give you material to keep, change or set aside.

Try a small version

Keep a short original draft. If you want, return after a pause and notice one thing you would keep or change. You choose whether another version helps.

A route you can adapt

Where would you want to practice that choice: on your own, with a willing collaborator, or with a teacher, librarian or music mentor?

VOCABULARY & SOUND · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2010

Eminem

Give yourself more words to choose from.

In 2010, Eminem discussed dictionary reading for vocabulary and demonstrated rhyming through pronunciation in his interview with Anderson Cooper.

CBS / 60 Minutes · first published October 10, 2010; updated 2011 (https://www.cbsnews.com/news/eminems-incredible-rise-to-stardom-07-08-2011/)

What to take from it

Studying words can mean noticing their meaning and sound. This historical account does not establish a current daily routine or formal study of linguistics. Longer or rarer words are not automatically better choices.

Try a small version

Choose an ordinary word. Find another meaning or a word with a similar sound. Write two original lines, then keep the wording that fits your idea.

A route you can adapt

Try your own word notebook, a dictionary from a library, or a conversation with a language or music teacher. Ask what changes in meaning and sound between two choices.

RHYTHM & LISTENING · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2020

Rakim

Listen for something you can change.

In a 2020 interview, Rakim recalled learning instruments as a child and studying jazz timing with his brother at a community center. He described using John Coltrane's saxophone phrasing as an influence on his rap delivery.

The Believer · John O'Connor · April 1, 2020 (https://www.thebeliever.net/an-interview-with-rakim/)

What to take from it

He connected earlier music learning with later choices about rhythm and space. You can explore a pause or a pattern without owning an instrument or copying another artist's words.

Try a small version

Tap four steady beats. Speak an original sentence twice, changing where you pause. Or mark pauses on paper and imagine the difference. Which version suits the sentence?

A route you can adapt

Ask a music teacher, community tutor or willing collaborator to help you hear or mark one rhythm. A poetry or drama activity can also be a place to try pauses.

PEER LEARNING & TECHNIQUE · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2025

Lupe Fiasco

Make a specific part of the craft learnable.

In a 2025 Johns Hopkins interview, Lupe Fiasco recalled sharing verses and getting feedback from other rappers at high school. He also described teaching rap techniques and introducing experienced rappers to linguistics and communication theory through the Society of Spoken Art.

Johns Hopkins University / The Hub · Aleyna Rentz · January 7, 2025 (https://hub.jhu.edu/2025/01/07/lupe-fiasco-joins-peabody-faculty/)

What to take from it

Linguistics studies how language works. Sounds, meanings and how people communicate can be things to investigate in your own writing. His teaching roles are not evidence of an earned university degree, and you do not need a university place to try a small experiment.

Try a small version

Pick one question: Does this word have two meanings? Where does the important sound land? Ask a willing listener what they notice, or compare two versions privately.

A route you can adapt

Choose one question for a writing group, library resource, teacher or music mentor. Ask for help with that specific choice rather than a judgment of your whole piece.

MUSIC LEARNING & REHEARSAL · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2023

Doechii

Practice can include a whole performance.

After her 2023 Coachella debut, Doechii told UPROXX that performing-arts high school included chorus, writing music and music theory. She also described rehearsing with her band and dancers every day for two weeks before the show.

UPROXX · Cherise Johnson · April 20, 2023 (https://uproxx.com/music/doechii-interview-coachella-2023/)

What to take from it

This is her account of one education experience and one show. It offers a look at preparation, not a timetable you need to match. A short, comfortable rehearsal can focus on one choice.

Try a small version

Use two original lines or the invented practice example. Try a clear pause in one version and a different emphasis in another. You can work silently on paper; recording and performing are optional.

A route you can adapt

Try a chorus, music or drama class, an established community program, or a willing collaborator. Ask for feedback on one part, such as the pace or a pause.

01 / WRITING & REVISION · ABOUT 5–7 MINUTES

Four lines. Two versions.

Make a listener picture an invented scene. Write, speak quietly, or think it through. No rhyme or performance is required.

Original teaching example · fictional scene

The last bus pulled away.
I stood under the shelter.
The rain was loud.
I waited for a ride.

1. **Start your own scene.** Use four lines about an ordinary object or fictional moment. You can also work from the example.
2. **Keep the first version.** On paper, in your own notes, or in memory. You can pause and return later if that helps.
3. **Change one thing.** Replace a vague detail, move a pause, or cut a word that does not help. Your language variety is not a mistake.
4. **Compare.** What changed in the picture, meaning or sound? A revision can be different without being better.

See one possible revision

The last bus pulled away.
I folded my ticket twice.
Rain rattled the shelter roof.
I watched for familiar headlights.

This version adds visible and audible details. You might prefer the first version's simplicity. The choice depends on what you want the listener to notice.

If you want feedback

Ask a willing listener what they remember and where they lose the idea. Share only work you choose. You can disagree with a suggestion.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? “No connection” is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Bring two versions of a paragraph, presentation or verse to a teacher or tutor. Ask: “Which detail makes the idea clearer?”

What is left from a $500 show?

Invented scenario. Two collaborators receive a $500 fee. Travel costs $75 and an engineer costs $125. They agree to keep $100 for a future project and split the rest equally.

1. Subtract the two expenses. How much cash remains?
2. Set aside the agreed reserve. How much is available to split?
3. Divide that amount between the two people.
4. What needs to be agreed before the show? What cost might be missing?

Compare with the worked example

Fee received	$500
Travel + engineer	−$200
Cash after those expenses	$300
Agreed project reserve	−$100
Available to distribute	$200
Each person's share	$100

The reserve is cash kept for later, not automatically another expense. This does not calculate taxable profit or final after-tax income. Ask who approves costs, when payment happens and what happens if a cost changes.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? “No connection” is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Ask a math teacher or tutor to check your explanation of the split. For a real paid opportunity, ask a trusted adult to help find qualified advice about terms, rights and payment.

Same words. Different emphasis.

Change what a listener notices without changing the words. Speak privately, mark the sentence on paper, or think through the meanings. No recording or hearing task is required.

Original teaching sentence

We can start the track tomorrow.

1. Put the emphasis on **we**. What might that suggest about who will start?
2. Move it to **start**, then **tomorrow**. What changes?
3. Try a pause after "track." Mark it with a slash if you prefer. Does that create a different expectation?
4. Choose an emphasis for an original line of your own. What do you want a listener to notice?

Compare three possible readings

WE might contrast this group with somebody else. **START** might distinguish beginning from finishing. **TOMORROW** might contrast tomorrow with today. Context could change all three readings; these are possibilities, not correct answers.

In her January 8, 2014 Sonicbids interview (https://blog.sonicbids.com/rapsody-interview), Rapsody discussed cadence and melody. This is our emphasis exercise, not her method. Read her process story.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? "No connection" is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Ask a teacher, tutor or drama/music mentor to compare two readings of a sentence from an assignment you choose. Your language variety is not an error; timing and emphasis are only part of delivery.

A reference that earns its place.

A factual detail can give a line another layer. Try the source cards below without internet, or choose a topic and sources of your own.

Source A · NASA

Our paraphrase: The Moon reflects a small part of the sunlight that reaches it.

Moonlight (https://science.nasa.gov/moon/moonlight/) · NASA Science · updated February 12, 2026 · explanation of reflected light.

Source B · ESA

Our paraphrase: ESA compares planets reflecting starlight with our Moon reflecting sunlight.

What do exoplanets look like? (https://www.esa.int/Science_Exploration/Space_Science/Exoplanets/What_do_exoplanets_look_like) · European Space Agency · "Clouds and surface" section · no publication date displayed; checked October 2, 2026.

1. **State the narrow fact.** What do both cards support? What would go beyond them?
2. **Check where it came from.** These are explanations from two agencies. Neither page attributes this explanation to the other. They are not two new experiments. Two headlines repeating one interview would still be one origin.
3. **Make two original lines.** Use the idea and keep a source note. Rhyme is optional. A metaphor can be imagined; a factual claim needs support.
4. **Ask if it belongs.** Does the detail help your scene or meaning, or is it there only to sound impressive?

Compare with one original example

The Moon sends borrowed sunlight down.
I carry yesterday's idea through town.

The first line uses reflected sunlight; "borrowed" is a metaphor. The second line is imagined. The sources do not prove anything about a person's memories, mood or music.

GZA's 2015 account gives one example of curiosity becoming material. This source-checking activity is our teaching choice, not a method he endorsed.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? "No connection" is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

If useful, ask a librarian or subject teacher to check your claim. The source cards above work offline.

Same moment. Two viewpoints.

Give two people different information without making either one the villain. Use this fictional scene; you do not need to describe a real disagreement.

> Invented rehearsal scene
>
> Alex thinks rehearsal begins at four. Jordan thinks it begins at five. They are reading different versions of a message. Neither has checked which version is current.

1. Write, speak privately or imagine two lines from Alex's view. What does Alex know? What is still an assumption?
2. Try two lines from Jordan's view. Let the difference come from information, not a stereotype about either person.
3. Choose what a listener should understand that the characters do not yet know.
4. Write one useful question the collaborators could ask to check the plan.

Compare one possible pair

Alex: “The saved note says four; I’m ready by the door.”

Jordan: “My screen says five; I think I’m right on time.”

These original fictional lines show why each person might believe the schedule. A useful question is: “Which message is the latest, and can we confirm the time together?” Neither person's first belief is proof that the other ignored them.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? “No connection” is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Compare point of view in a story or assignment with a teacher or tutor. For a group project, agree how changes will be confirmed. This is an original teaching exercise; storytelling is one musical choice, not a rule for every rap.

Choose a part. Move it around.

Production includes decisions about what returns and where it lands. Try a small arrangement using material you make for this exercise. Write, speak privately, quietly tap, or imagine it. No hearing task or recording is required.

Four original teaching phrases

Doors open.
Lights low.
Ready now.
Take a breath.

1. **Make four parts.** Invent four short phrases, patterns or descriptions of sounds. You can use our phrases instead.
2. **Choose one part.** What do you want someone to notice? Repeat that part once.
3. **Change the placement.** Try the repeat earlier or later, or put a pause before it. Keep two versions on paper, in your notes or in memory.
4. **Explain the difference.** What changes in the meaning, pattern or feeling? Choose a version, combine them, or decide the repeat does not help.

Compare two possible arrangements

Version A: Doors open. Lights low. Ready now. Ready now. Take a breath.

Version B: Doors open. Lights low. Ready now. Take a breath. [pause] Ready now.

A could make readiness feel insistent. B could make the last phrase feel like a decision after a breath. You may read them differently. Neither arrangement is the correct one.

A collaborator is optional

Ask a willing person what they notice and invite one alternative. Explain your goal before comparing. You can keep your first choice; feedback is a suggestion. A solo or silent response works too.

Badu's account of a lesson with J Dilla offers one collaboration example. These phrases and this exercise are ours, not their music or method.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? "No connection" is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Compare repetition or a pause in a speech, reading or group project with a teacher or mentor. Practice explaining a choice and asking a clear feedback question.

One word. More choices.

Choose a word for what it does in your piece. A familiar word can do a lot. Write, speak quietly or think it through; a dictionary is optional.

Original teaching example · invented sentences

Word: light
Meaning choices: brightness; not heavy
Sound family: night, bright, out of sight

The room filled with light.

I kept my bag light.

1. **Choose one word.** Try “light,” “break” or a word from your own idea. Use a dictionary if you want another meaning; the example works offline.
2. **Follow the meaning.** Explain what your word means in this line. Could a listener understand it another way?
3. **Follow the sound.** Find two words or a short phrase that repeat a sound you like. You can speak them, imagine them or mark the sounds on paper. Your pronunciation and language variety belong in the experiment.
4. **Make and compare.** Write or imagine two original lines. Change one word or phrase. Which meaning or sound helps your idea? You can prefer the simpler version or decide rhyme adds nothing.

One way to compare choices

In the example, “light” changes meaning between the two sentences. “Bright” shares a sound with “light,” but replacing one with the other could change the grammar and meaning. A rhyme is a possibility, not a reason to give up the idea you meant.

A dictionary can offer meanings and pronunciation. It cannot choose the best line for you. You do not have to memorize a book or collect rare words.

Read the vocabulary story or the peer-learning story. These sentences and this exercise are ours.

Does this help your goal?

How might it help? “No connection” is fine. Adapt or skip this option:

Keep a small word notebook from reading or listening that interests you. Or ask a language teacher, librarian or music mentor to compare the meaning and sound of two choices. You decide which route helps.

A week you can rearrange.

Choose one music goal and one learning or support goal. Try small steps around your actual life. Move days, shorten a task, stop, or use just one idea.

Start with your choices

On paper, in your own notes or in your head: "I want more control over _____ in my music. One learning question I want help with is _____." Choose a reliable person you already know or can meet through an established school, library or youth program.

In her 2020 account, Megan described fitting studies around music. These seven steps are our proposal, not her schedule or advice. You do not need to copy a celebrity's workload.

1 · Pick a small target

Music: Choose clearer imagery, delivery, a reference or understanding a budget.

Learning: Pick one question about an assignment, skill, credit or learning option. Name someone who could help.

2 · Collect a detail

Music: Notice three details about an ordinary object or invented place.

Learning: Read, listen to or discuss a short passage. Keep one question for a teacher or librarian.

3 · Check a reference

Music: Try two lines with a checked fact, or use the provided Moon example.

Learning: Identify what a source supports. Ask for source help if you need it.

4 · Keep two versions

Music: Try a second version of four lines.

Learning: Apply one revision to an assignment you choose, or ask a tutor to compare two versions with you.

5 · Explain the money

Music: Explain the split in the invented $500 show.

Learning: Practice the subtraction/division, or ask a math teacher or tutor where the calculation gets confusing.

6 · Try a step if it fits

Music: Read, speak privately or silently review a short piece, or compare two arrangements.

Learning: If useful, try one action: practice a music skill independently, use a library resource, ask a collaborator or tutor for help, begin an assignment, or ask a counselor about credits/options. If the action is blocked, asking about the barrier counts as a useful step.

7 · Keep what helped

Music: Compare what changed and what you want to keep.

Learning: Name one helpful thing and one difficulty. Choose a realistic next action, change the plan, or choose none.

Make the support request concrete

"Could you help me with _____? I can try _____ at _____. The part that might get in the way is _____." You decide what to share.

If you are not enrolled, ask an education worker about locally appropriate options and eligibility. Safety, transport, work, money and learning access may need practical support beyond an activity. A shortened plan is still a choice you can make.

No reminders, streaks, grades or submission. This plan has not been tested for school outcomes; it is a way to try connecting your own goals.

YOUR NEXT STEP

What would help right now?

Pick something useful, or leave it for another time. You do not have to explain your personal history.

Get better at writing

Choose one thing: a clearer scene, stronger delivery or useful feedback.

> **“Can you look at these two versions and tell me where the idea gets clearer?”**

Try a teacher, tutor, librarian or a trusted person in an established arts program.

Check a fact or reference

Choose one claim you want to use in music or an assignment.

> **“Does this source support what I wrote, and where could I check it?”**

Try a librarian or subject teacher. Use the provided offline source cards if browsing is not available.

Explain a creative choice

Compare two arrangements, placements or pauses.

> **“This is what I want someone to notice. What changes between these versions?”**

Try a music or drama teacher, mentor or willing listener in an established arts program. Ask before sharing; you choose what to keep.

Catch up or check my credits

Ask a school counselor or education support worker about one missing assignment, credit or enrollment question.

> **“What is one realistic step, and who can help me take it?”**

If you are not enrolled, ask about locally approved options and eligibility. You do not need to decide on a pathway from this page.

Understand music business

Start with a budget or write questions about an invented offer.

> **“What will I actually receive, what work is expected, and who controls the recording?”**

For real agreements, involve a trusted adult and qualified advice. Do not share a contract or personal information with strangers online.

School is not working for me

Safety, transport, learning support, work and missing credits need practical help.

> **“This is the part I need help with. What can we change first?”**

Choose a reliable counselor, teacher, caregiver, youth advocate or education worker you already know or can meet through a trusted organization.

I need money now

A future plan does not pay today's bill. Ask a trusted adult or youth-program staff member about age-appropriate work and immediate support, alongside education options.

You decide how much to explain. This site cannot provide a job, case management or financial support.

I am not sure yet

You can try one activity without making a plan. You can also choose no next step right now.

When you want to, start with: “I want music to help me do _____. One thing I want to understand is _____.”

Make the request concrete

If you choose an action, decide what you will ask, who you can ask and when it is realistic. A support person should follow their organization's safeguarding rules. You can stop, change the plan or choose another person.

FOR TEACHERS, MENTORS & CAREGIVERS

Offer a practice. Listen to the response.

A flexible 20–25 minute session for an individual or small group. Initial age assumption: 13–18. No account, performance or disclosure is needed.

Before the session

Read a story, try an activity and check the source note. Bring paper and pencils, or open the offline packet. Offer reading aloud, silent reflection and spoken responses. Do not infer reading level from age. Let the participant select a skill without choosing an artist.

Explain your setting's actual confidentiality limits. A program's rules still apply even when the website collects nothing.

1. **Invite · 2 minutes.** "Would you like to try something connected to writing or music?" Declining is fine.
2. **Choose · 3 minutes.** Let them select a story or go directly to an activity. Ask what the artist actually practiced. Then ask what the participant wants to make or understand; allow no connection.
3. **Try · 5–7 minutes.** Use a fictional scene or the invented budget. No public performance; keep creative work private.
4. **Reflect · 5 minutes.** "What changed? What did not help? Did this add pressure or make the goal feel harder?" Discuss the intended meaning, not whether their dialect is correct.
5. **Connect · 5 minutes.** "Could a class, library, program or person help with this?" Accept that a connection may feel forced.
6. **Close · 2 minutes.** Offer a voluntary next action and a reliable support route. Name who can help and how contact would happen.

If someone disagrees

"My favorite rapper dropped out." Artists' paths vary. Black Thought's story here includes leaving college. That does not explain what caused success or choose a path for you.

"I do not need college to make music." A college credential is not a universal requirement. What learning and support fit your goal?

"I am already good with words." Start with that strength. Which part would you like more control over?

"School has not helped me." What has been missing or unhelpful? A practical response may matter more than another activity.

"I need money now." Let's find a person who can help with immediate options and a plan that fits.

"You want me to give up music." You choose the music goal. This resource offers practice, learning choices and help.

Use and evaluation are different

This local prototype has not been youth-tested. It has no evidence of improving attendance, graduation or justice outcomes. It does not establish how common any belief is.

Before a pilot with minors, a qualified partner must establish appropriate permission, assent/consent, safeguarding, review, accessibility and data handling. Do not recruit or record from this prototype. Participation must not affect grades, privileges, legal treatment or services. Never request charges, case histories, trauma or autobiographical lyrics.